

Altair on the Silverscreen

Sony Pictures in talks with Ubisoft to bring Assassins Creed to the big screens

Glow in the Dark PS3

Wireless controllers manufactured by PDP with exciting features

Good Old Games

Good Old Games (GOG) is not only a digital game store, but also a stand against DRM. The company behind GOG is none other than CD Projekt, the creators of the popular *The Witcher* game series.

All games in its store are offered without any DRM, and don't need any client to run. The games are simple set-up files that can be installed on any Windows computer. A downloader for games is available, but optional.

GOG offers hundreds of mostly old games, some as old as 1986 (*King's Quest*) while others as recent as this year, 2011 (*The Witcher II: The Assassins of Kings*). If you're looking for classic PC games, then in many cases this is the only source.

It does more than offer the games though. Firstly GOG goes out of its way to ensure that games work on latest versions of Windows – in the case of some very old games, this means using emulators such as DOSBox or ScummVM.

Secondly, it usually bundles extra content with each game, such as additional maps, manuals, soundtracks, avatars, artwork, guides, etc. This content is unique to GOG.

Games are offered at only two prices, ₹299 and ₹499. In some case entire game collections are available at these price points.

Pros:

- All games are DRM free
- No client to download/play games
- Most games have bundled freebies
- Some games are game collections
- Cheap games; some free games

Cons:

- Limited to mostly old games

Green Man Gaming

This service is unique in that it tries to bring one of the most lucrative aspects of boxed game copies, trading copies, to the digital world. Games you purchase on the service can be played as normal, and then traded back in exchange for credit to buy another game.

Because of this, Green Man Gaming often has the lowest rates of any game distribution web site even for com-

Online Stores

- You can buy games in a few clicks, and start downloading instantly
- Games are HUGE, downloading that much will take loads of time and need good bandwidth
- Online games tend to be at international prices
- No storage required for a game box, better on the environment (no plastic disc, no cardboard box)
- Games in stores are often much cheaper
- Most stores will let you re-download your game as many times as you want indefinitely
- Online stores often have sales that are known to go even in the "90% off" area

pletely new or even unreleased games. The trade-in prices can fluctuate based on demand and supply, so you can even make money by buying, playing and then selling a game.

Due to the unique nature of this game store, it needs you to install a client to download and play games. Its DRM ensures that you can play a game when you buy it, but not once you've traded it back. Not all games are tradable though, be careful before you buy!

Considering the already cheap game prices, and the fact that games once played can be returned, this is often the cheapest route to playing a game.

Pros:

- Games can be traded back, thus saving great deals of money
- Game prices are usually lower than those of competing stores
- Constant sales and promotions

Cons:

- Purchase and trade-in prices are fickle
- Client necessary to download and play.

BeamDog

BeamDog is a digital game distribution platform recently launched by one of BioWare's co-founders and an ex-BioWare lead developer, aiming to simplify game download and play experience.

Offline vs Online

Offline Stores

- Offline sales are less common, and usually very limited in discount
- No download required
- You can need to go to a store to get the game (there are online stores that sell boxed games as well)
- Game boxes are a nice souvenir (I stay mostly at home, what's this environment thing?)
- Unless the game's tied with an online store, if you break the disc, your game is lost



To this end, BeamDog, like Steam, downloads your game in a ready-to-play form, so you can jump right in after the download is done. You need the game client to download and launch the games, however DRM is not enforced. In fact BeamDog offers numerous free and even Open Source games such as *LinCity*, *Battle for Wesnoth*, *FreeCiv*, *Hedgewars* etc.

The way BeamDog works is very similar to Steam, but the client doesn't include extraneous social features and is just focused on buying, downloading and playing. The BeamDog web site however offers some amount of social features by allowing you to have a profile and follow others.

BeamDog has hundreds of games, but its catalogue is quite small. Considering how new this service is – it just launched in July 2010 – this isn't very surprising.

Pros:

- No mandatory DRM
- Selection of good free games
- Clean focused client software
- Games play directly after install
- Games can be installed on whatever drive you want to install it to

Cons:

- Small selection of games
- Client necessary to download games 